

FLASHPOINT

POLESTAR INSIGHTS

REPORTING PERIOD: 18 MAY 2026 - 24 MAY 2026

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This briefing covers the activism, protest and civil-unrest picture across 18 May 2026 - 24 May 2026. The detailed operational read, country breakdown, forecast and analyst sections follow below.

FAST FACTS

REPORTING PERIOD 18 May - 24 May 2026	RECORDS IN WINDOW 34 24 activism, 5 civil unrest	HIGHEST SEVERITY High Worst rating in window
TOP ISSUE TYPE Protest 21 records	MOST AFFECTED COUNTRY Pakistan 8 records	LATEST INCIDENT 23 May 2026

ACTIVISM AND PROTEST READ

The activism picture across the briefing window (18 May - 24 May 2026) is anchored on protest reporting, with "Opposition lawmakers stage protest in National Assembly, demand medical care for Imran" as the lead entry. The mix breaks down as protest (18) and strike / labour action (6).

For operators, the practical read is that named opposition movements, sectoral unions and student bodies remain the primary drivers of street-level disruption. Roads, transport hubs and city-centre commercial districts are the typical pressure points; staff movement, last-mile logistics and customer-facing footfall are the first surfaces to feel the effect.

ACTIVISM RECORDS

DATE	ISSUE	TITLE	SEVERITY
23 May 2026	Protest	Hundreds rally in Taipei for defence spending after parliament cuts funds - Yahoo News Malaysia	LOW
23 May 2026	Protest	PTI launches protest drive for Imran's release	HIGH
22 May 2026	Protest	Bangladesh Labour Congress-BNC holds a protest march in front of the National Press Club in the capital on Friday, demanding justice for the brutal murder and rape of all daughters and women, including Ramisa. - The New Nation	LOW
22 May 2026	Protest	Licensable picture: Protest Against Child Rape In Dhaka, Bangladesh - Reuters Connect	LOW
22 May 2026	Protest	Licensable picture: Protest In Bangladesh - Reuters Connect	LOW
22 May 2026	Protest	Greenlanders protest outside US consulate's new office - Bangladesh Sangbad Sangstha (BSS)	LOW
22 May 2026	Protest	Rights organisations protest over brutal rape-murder of minor girl in Bangladesh - The Assam Tribune	LOW
22 May 2026	Protest	Bangladesh Anti India Protest BJP TMC , , BJP india procession in bangladesh comment bjp vic , - anti	MODERATE

DATE	ISSUE	TITLE	SEVERITY
21 May 2026	Strike / labour action	Samsung workers' union suspends planned strike - The Manila Times	LOW
21 May 2026	Protest	French Open players plan media protest over prize money share - The Manila Times	LOW
21 May 2026	Protest	Licensable picture: Protest in solidarity with Palestinians and Global Sumud Flotilla in Jakarta - Reuters Connect	LOW
21 May 2026	Protest	Imran's cases will be fixed after Eid, CJP assures PTI	MODERATE

CIVIL UNREST AND PUBLIC ORDER READ

Civil unrest in the briefing window (18 May - 24 May 2026) carries a highest severity of low, led by "(LEAD) Ex-NIS deputy chief denies allegations of delivering message backing Yoon's martial law".

The composition is dominated by curfew / emergency order (4) and riot / public disorder (1).

Operationally, crackdowns and curfew orders matter more than the headline protest count: they signal where the state is prepared to escalate enforcement and where staff movement, commercial operations and venue access can be disrupted at short notice. Where security-force operations cluster around a single city or district, expect rolling road closures and intermittent connectivity.

CIVIL UNREST RECORDS

DATE	ISSUE	TITLE	SEVERITY
22 May 2026	Curfew / emergency order	Probe under way over alleged irregular drone acquisition linked to Yoon's martial law bid	LOW
22 May 2026	Curfew / emergency order	(LEAD) Ex-NIS deputy chief denies allegations of delivering message backing Yoon's martial law	LOW
21 May 2026	Curfew / emergency order	(LEAD) Ex-spy chief Cho Tae-yong sentenced to 1 1/2 yrs in prison for perjury in martial law trial	LOW
18 May 2026	Curfew / emergency order	(LEAD) Lee says 1980 pro-democracy movement was reborn in thwarting 2024 martial law forces	LOW
18 May 2026	Riot / public disorder	4 courthouse rioters get suspended terms for attacking reporters	LOW

FORECAST: NEXT 7-14 DAYS

COUNTRY	SIGNAL	OPERATIONAL MEANING
Bangladesh	Protest mobilisation	Treat as leading indicator; confirm operating impact inside 24-48h.
Philippines	Union injunction ruling	Sectoral disruption pending court ruling; pre-position contingency supply.
Pakistan	PTI mobilisation for Imran's release	Road closures and venue-access friction around party HQs, court complexes and city centres.
India	Chemists' strike notice	Pharmacy supply disruption 24-72h ahead; brief procurement and customer-care.
Pakistan	Sectoral pay protest	Sectoral walkout risk; brief logistics and field operations on local delays.
South Korea	Union injunction ruling	Sectoral disruption pending court ruling; pre-position contingency supply.

Confirmed forward-looking items are listed in the table above and should be the first reference points for the next 7-14 days. The trajectory commentary below sits behind that scheduled calendar.

Across the next 7-14 days, Pakistan is likely to remain the leading source of activism and civil-unrest reporting on current cadence, with 8 records on file this cycle. Adjacent cities and university campuses are possible secondary flashpoints.

Activism reporting dominates the current mix, so the most likely escalation path is from announced rallies and sectoral walkouts into intermittent road closures and city-centre disruption. Risk increases if security forces respond with mass arrests, tear gas or curfew orders; risk eases if organisers stand down voluntarily or political talks open.

Cautious read: a thin cycle is not a sustained easing in these geographies. A single political event can repopulate the file inside 48 hours, so the forecast should be treated as a baseline rather than a prediction.

REGIONAL AND COUNTRY VIEW

Across the briefing window the file leans on Pakistan with 8 records against 7 for South Korea and 6 for Bangladesh.

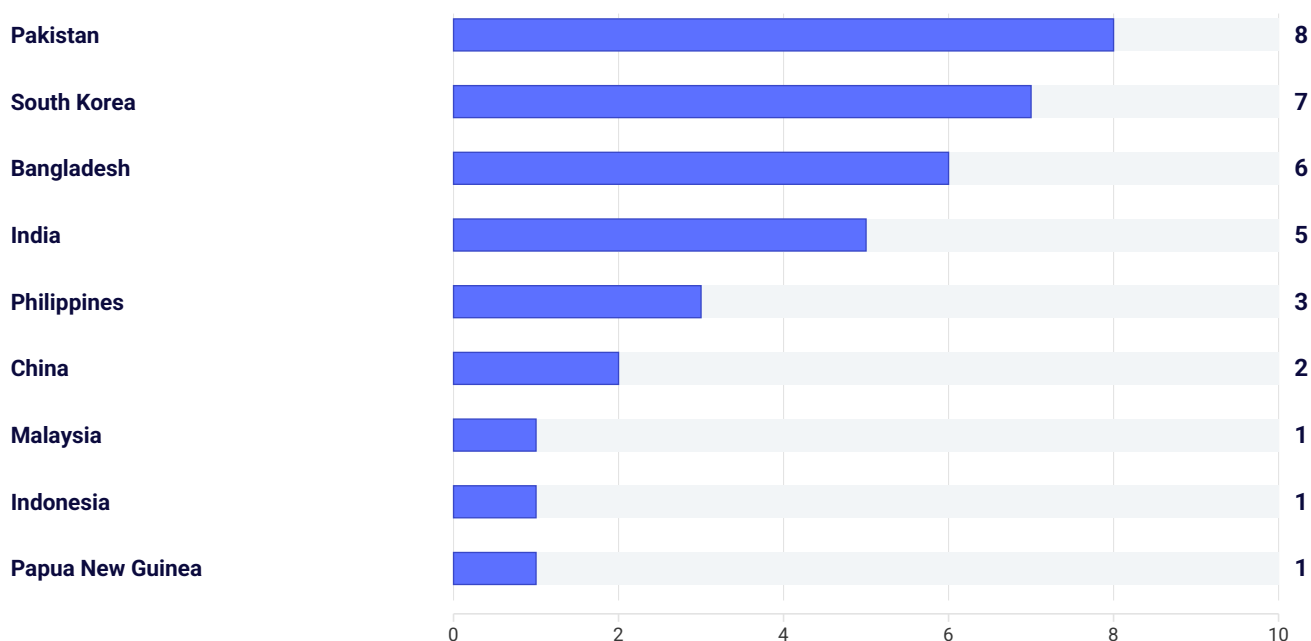
Pakistan - 8 records, driven by protest. Likely form: announced rallies, sectoral walkouts and student-body actions converting into rolling road closures; main disruption loci: city-centre commercial districts, transport hubs and government precincts.

South Korea - 7 records, driven by curfew / emergency order alongside strike / labour action. Likely form: announced rallies and sectoral walkouts that routinely draw a visible enforcement response; main disruption loci: city-centre commercial districts, government precincts and university campuses.

Bangladesh - 6 records, driven by protest. Likely form: announced rallies, sectoral walkouts and student-body actions converting into rolling road closures; main disruption loci: city-centre commercial districts, transport hubs and government precincts.

A further 6 countries carry low-volume entries; see chart below.

RECORDS BY COUNTRY



WHAT MATTERS

The cycle's centre of gravity sits with Pakistan, which carries 8 records across the activism and civil-unrest mix. That matters operationally because protest cadence in Pakistan routinely converts into rolling road closures, intermittent connectivity disruption and pressure on staff movement at short notice.

Activism reporting (24) running alongside civil-unrest reporting (5) is the classic pattern when announced rallies are routinely met with police orders, selective detentions and tear-gas dispersal. The risk profile sits in the second-order response: curfew impositions, internet shutdowns and mass arrests usually follow a single high-visibility incident rather than a slow build.

IMPLICATIONS FOR BUSINESS

- Review staff movement plans and journey-management routings across Pakistan against the live protest calendar.
- Set clear work-from-home or delayed-start triggers for offices, plants and customer-facing sites in affected cities.
- Confirm alternative routes for staff, visitors and delivery movements around courts, ministries, campuses and party offices.
- Harden site access controls, perimeter checks and visitor restrictions; pre-position guard reinforcement.
- Pre-approve staff, customer and regulator communications for disruption days so messages move in minutes, not hours.
- Monitor Section 144 / curfew orders, arrests, injuries and any internet-shutdown notices in cities of operation.
- Wire procurement, distribution and customer-service into the security early-warning feed - sectoral walkouts and campus calls lead street action by 24-72 hours.

WATCH NEXT

- Bangladesh - Protest mobilisation: road closures and venue-access friction; brief drivers in advance.
- Philippines - Union injunction ruling: supply-chain friction and sectoral closures 24-72h ahead.
- Pakistan - PTI mobilisation for Imran's release: road closures and venue-access friction; brief drivers in advance.
- India - Chemists' strike notice: supply-chain friction and sectoral closures 24-72h ahead.
- Pakistan - Sectoral pay protest: road closures and venue-access friction; brief drivers in advance.
- South Korea - Union injunction ruling: supply-chain friction and sectoral closures 24-72h ahead.

POLESTAR VIEW

Mobilisation capacity across Pakistan is non-trivial this cycle, drawing on named-movement organising (5) and sectoral chamber and union action (6) - multiple independent vectors, harder to contain than a single-issue wave.

Speed of escalation looks measured, but the runway is short - historically 24-72 hours from a peaceful announced rally to a kinetic incident once a political trigger lands.

Likely protest geography over the next 7-14 days: Pakistan (8 records) sets the tempo and South Korea (7) is the most likely secondary flashpoint. Expect clustering around court complexes, party HQs, ministry quarters, campuses and main commercial arteries.

Business disruption risk over the next window is moderate-to-elevated: short-notice transport disruption on protest days, public-facing site closures driven by Section 144 / curfew orders, and supply-chain friction from sectoral walkouts. The residual tail is a triggering event - adverse ruling, fuel-price decision, security-force fatality - flipping the cycle into sustained unrest.

RELATED INCIDENTS

DATE	ISSUE	TITLE	SEVERITY
21 May 2026	Protest	Imran's cases will be fixed after Eid, CJP assures PTI	MODERATE
20 May 2026	Strike / labour action	Chemists strike on May 20: Why Indian pharmacists are protesting e-pharmacies over rules, pricing and safety	HIGH
23 May 2026	Protest	PTI launches protest drive for Imran's release	HIGH
20 May 2026	Protest	Afridi, Aleema claim shots were fired at Adiala sit-in participants	HIGH
19 May 2026	Protest	TTAP, PTI announces countrywide protests on Friday against Imran's imprisonment, rising inflation	HIGH
18 May 2026	Protest	JI emir challenges petroleum levy in FCC, terms it 'unconstitutional'	HIGH

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